the TMC regime has moved in hurriedly to contain the damage—Shahjahan was suspended for six years, two ministers were deployed to placate villagers and expiatory grievance redressal camps started—Sandeshkhali is now a weapon in the hands of the Opposition, a by-word, they say, of TMC "misrule". At a rally in Arambagh, in Hooghly district, on March 1, Prime Minister Narendra Modi drove home the point. "Atrocities...on Sandeshkhali women have crossed all limits. When women sought help from (West Bengal chief minister) Mamata Banerjee, her government made attempts to protect (the accused) TMC leaders," he said. "Will you forgive TMC? For every wound inflicted, reply with your vote," he exhorted. On March 5, the Calcutta High Court ordered a Central Bureau of Investigation (CBI) probe into the attack on the ED team in Sandeshkhali. The same day, the state government moved the Supreme Court against the HC order.

From diverting funds received under state and central welfare schemes, including the Pradhan Mantri Awas Yojana (PMAY), to encroaching on government and private land, from demanding a 'cut' from beneficiaries of schemes to sexual misconduct, allegations voiced by residents of the Sandeshkhali blocks paint a picture of Shahjahan's iron-fisted rule and how his diktats came to represent the administration there. Sandeshkhali is a Hindu-majority area, with Scheduled Castes (36.45 per cent) and Scheduled Tribes (24.55 per cent) comprising a major chunk of the population (the assembly seat is an ST reserved one). Significantly, Muslim residents (30-35 per cent) also echoed Hindus in castigating Shahjahan. What exactly was his racket?

A Fishy Enterprise

Septuagenarian Nagen Sardar of Bermajur village alleges that the *bheri* (the Bengali term for fishery/ fishpond) committee took away an acre of a fishery pond he owned. "The committee members came two months back and declared that they will seize my pond. I was allocated someone else's pond, but that person drove me away. I am unemployed now," Nagen tells INDIA TODAY.

Set up by Shahjahan—also in charge of the district's fisheries development—the dreaded 'bheri committee', with no formal government approval, comprised local TMC henchmen, locals claim. Committee members would grab a piece of land or pond without arranging for any compensation. Sometimes, the ponds would be taken on lease from owners, but payments would stop after a few months, they say. Farmland would also be seized and turned into fisheries project, which yields a higher income. Like Nagen, Krishna Sardar, a farmer from Bermajur, alleges that Shankar Sardar and Ajit Maiti, representatives of the local TMC-led panchayat samiti, took away an acre of his farmland for fisheries use and threatened to pump saline water into the field if he did not give it up. "Not only did they take it away, I also had to pay Rs 1 lakh to keep my home," charges Krishna. Both Nagen and Krishna have submitted complaints, as well as ownership documents, at the grievance redressal camp in the Bermajur Polpara FP School, hoping to retrieve their land.

For over a decade, people in the Sandeshkhali area have also had to pay a price for every government benefit they were entitled to. Rates for everything were fixed, even goat kids or chicks meant for self-help groups

SHAHJAHAN AND HIS MEN THEMSELVES WOULD DEAL WITH LAW & ORDER ISSUES. DISSENTERS WOULD BE BRUTALISED, ALLEGE LOCALS

Catalogue of Misdeeds

While the attack on ED officials is the ostensible reason for Shahjahan's arrest, the people of Sandeshkhali have a whole litany of allegations against him



- Shahjahan's followers brutally thrash ED officials on January 5, when they go to raid his house. The arrested TMC strongman is charged with attempt to murder, grievous hurt to public servants, rioting and robbery, among others
- Since February 7, scores of women have accused the leader as well as his henchmen of sexual assault and molestation after being asked to attend 'party meetings' at night
- Shahjahan and his men allegedly prevented people from filing nominations/ casting votes during elections
- Farm land and fishery ponds grabbed through an illegal 'Bheri committee'; little or no compensation paid
- Payment demanded against benefits from various government welfare schemes